

Investigation into the Activities of Foreign Microfinance Companies in Vietnam

Possible high-yield digital lending schemes in Vietnam involving fintech platforms, advisory services, and pawnshop-based structures, implemented with the participation of foreign capital and designed to generate profits from the rapidly growing consumer lending market amid limited regulatory oversight and an underdeveloped financial infrastructure.

1. Executive Summary of the Investigation

This report presents a preliminary analytical investigation of Vietnam's digital micro-lending market during the period from 2015 to 2026. The purpose of the study is to examine the business models of several fintech companies operating in the short-term online lending (PDL) sector and to identify potential mechanisms for the legal separation of lending activities among different entities, including consulting companies, pawnshop operators, financial marketplaces, IT firms, and intermediary service providers.

The investigation relied on publicly available sources, including loan agreements and terms of service, Vietnamese corporate registries (Masothue), LinkedIn profiles of employees and executives, analytical reports published by FiinGroup, articles from Reuters, Vietnam News, VietnamNet, and VnExpress, materials available through Scribd, user reviews and comments published on Google Play regarding microfinance services, as well as other open-source information.

The collected materials suggest the possible existence of a sustainable operating model in which customer acquisition, credit scoring, loan origination, fee generation, and debt collection activities may be distributed among several affiliated legal entities. Such a structure appears particularly visible in the case of a number of companies that have operated in the Vietnamese market since 2020.

This document does not allege wrongdoing by any specific individual or legal entity and does not reach definitive conclusions regarding violations of applicable laws or regulations. All information contained herein is derived from publicly available sources and is provided solely for further review and verification by competent government authorities, journalists, researchers, and market participants.

In the author's opinion, the information presented may be of interest to the Ministry of Public Security of Vietnam (MPS), the State Bank of Vietnam (SBV), tax authorities, financial investigation units, and members of the media examining the digital lending sector and consumer protection issues.

2. Methodology and Disclaimer

This study has been prepared on the basis of publicly available information and does not constitute an official government finding, audit report, legal opinion, forensic investigation, or accusatory document. Its purpose is to identify potential patterns, business models, and corporate relationships within Vietnam's digital micro-lending sector, as well as to formulate a set of issues that may warrant further examination.

The research is based on the principle of cross-referencing information obtained from multiple independent sources. In cases where specific information could be verified by only a single source, or where it originated from market participants, former employees, or other individuals without documentary confirmation, such information is expressly identified as alleged, unverified, or requiring further verification.

The author does not assert that any individual or legal entity mentioned in this document has engaged in unlawful conduct. The inclusion of any company, brand, employee, director, shareholder, consultant, or investor in this report should not be interpreted as evidence of guilt, participation in illegal activities, or violation of the laws of Vietnam or any other jurisdiction.

In many instances, the business models described herein may have legitimate explanations and may operate in compliance with applicable regulations. Nevertheless, certain elements of the identified structures—including the use of multiple legal entities within lending operations, consulting agreements, pawnshop-based arrangements, intermediary services used to generate additional fees, financial-service marketplaces, and other related mechanisms—may, in the author's opinion, warrant further review by competent authorities.

All findings, observations, and hypotheses contained in this document are analytical in nature and are intended solely for further study, verification, and discussion. Any definitive legal assessment of the facts described herein may only be made by duly authorized governmental authorities and courts based on a complete review of the relevant evidence.

Whenever this document uses expressions such as "allegedly," "according to market participants," "according to former employees," "possibly," "may indicate," "may suggest," or

similar language, such statements should be understood as working hypotheses rather than established facts.

3. Emergence of the PDL Market in Vietnam: 2015–2019

Vietnam's digital lending market began to develop rapidly during the period from 2015 to 2016, driven by the rapid expansion of mobile internet access, increasing smartphone penetration, and the limited availability of bank credit for a significant portion of the population. Despite the country's strong economic growth, millions of Vietnamese citizens remained underserved by the traditional financial system.

Estimated Size of Vietnam's Digital Micro-Lending Market

Indicator	Estimate
Population of Vietnam	~100 million
Smartphone users	~75–80 million
Unbanked and underbanked population	30–40 million people
Estimated alternative lending market size	USD 300 million
Major market participants	MoneyCat, Doctor Dong/Cay Vang, Takomo/Vay Xanh, MoneyVeo, VayVND, Robocash, and others

Obtaining a bank loan typically required documented income, formal employment, an established credit history, and the completion of lengthy verification procedures. As a result, conventional banking products remained inaccessible to a substantial segment of the population.

At the same time, Vietnam was undergoing a broader digital transformation of its financial sector. The number of smartphone users was growing rapidly, while mobile payments, electronic wallets, and instant bank transfer systems were becoming increasingly widespread. These developments created favorable conditions for the emergence of a new generation of fintech companies focused on fully digital, remote lending services.

The combination of strong consumer demand, limited access to traditional credit, and the rapid adoption of digital technologies made Vietnam one of the most attractive markets

in Southeast Asia for alternative lending providers and fintech-driven consumer finance businesses.

The first market participants introduced a fundamentally different model of interaction with borrowers. Instead of visiting a bank branch, customers could submit an application through a mobile app or website, upload a photograph of their identification document, provide bank account details, and receive a lending decision within minutes. This approach proved particularly attractive to individuals seeking relatively small amounts of money for short periods to address everyday financial needs.

It was during this period that brands such as Doctor Dong and Cashwagon emerged as some of the earliest and most visible participants in Vietnam’s short-term online lending (Payday Loan, PDL) sector. They were soon followed by other international operators from Russia, Eastern Europe, China, Singapore, and other countries in the region, many of which viewed Vietnam as one of the most promising digital lending markets in Southeast Asia.

The economics of these businesses were built around a combination of rapid loan disbursement, minimal borrower requirements, and the use of automated credit-scoring models. Unlike traditional banks, which generally targeted relatively affluent and financially established customers, digital lenders focused on consumers who faced difficulties accessing conventional financial services. For many Vietnamese borrowers, these platforms represented their first experience obtaining credit through the internet.

It should be noted that a number of fintech companies appeared to utilize a “pawnshop–broker” operating model. Under such arrangements, the online loan was formally structured through a licensed pawnshop entity with a nominal annual interest rate of approximately 20%, while a substantial portion of the overall charges and additional fees was transferred to a separate brokerage or service company. As a result, the total cost of borrowing for the customer could reportedly reach approximately 2% per day, equivalent to more than 700% on an annualized basis.

Example of a Legal Structure Separating a Pawnshop Entity and a Brokerage Entity with Additional Loan Charges: [Cay Vang](#) (formerly Doctor Dong):

Document	Loan Amount	Total Repayment Amount	Additional Charges	Annualized Equivalent Rate*
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Asset-lease-SA SA-signed + Pawn-Annex-S ASA-signed	1,000,000 VND	1,867,300 VND	867,300 VND	≈1,040–1,100% per annum
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*The calculation was performed by the author by converting the aggregate contractual charges into an annualized rate equivalent and does not represent the company's official APR or regulatory disclosure.

Takomo (EIB ASIA) (Operating under the [Vay Xanh](#) brand as of 2026)

Document	Loan Amount	Total Repayment Amount	Additional Charges	Annualized Equivalent Rate*
EIB ASIA / MANUTA	500,000 VND	607,500 VND after 10 days of delinquency; 887,500 VND after 30 days of delinquency	107,500–387,500 VND	≈ 785–943% per annum

*The calculation was performed by the author by converting the aggregate contractual charges into an annualized rate equivalent and does not represent the company's official APR or regulatory disclosure.

By 2018–2019, the sector had already evolved into a rapidly expanding segment of Vietnam's financial industry. Alongside lenders themselves, a supporting infrastructure began to emerge, including payment providers, credit-scoring platforms, digital identity verification services, marketing agencies, affiliate networks, and financial marketplaces. In effect, a complete digital micro-lending ecosystem had developed—one capable of attracting customers, making lending decisions, disbursing funds, and conducting debt collection activities with minimal human involvement.

However, the rapid expansion of the market was accompanied by increasing scrutiny from regulators and public authorities. By the end of the period under review, complaints had begun to emerge regarding the high cost of borrowing, non-transparent fee structures, aggressive debt collection practices, and the use of complex corporate arrangements in which different stages of the lending process could be distributed among multiple legal entities.

These developments ultimately contributed to the first major investigations of Vietnam's digital lending sector. Among the most widely reported cases was the investigation into

the activities of Cashwagon and a number of related entities, which attracted significant attention from regulators, law-enforcement agencies, and the media.

4. Basic Economics of Payday Loans (PDL)

To understand the subsequent development of Vietnam's digital micro-lending market, it is important to examine the underlying economic model used by most participants in the Payday Loan (PDL) sector. Although individual brands differed in their product offerings and operational structures, the lending terms and overall business logic employed by many companies were broadly similar.

The typical customer journey began with a small initial loan. New borrowers were commonly offered approximately 500,000 VND (roughly USD 15–20) for a period of 7 to 10 days. In many cases, the first loan was provided with no interest or only a minimal fee. Such products were primarily used as customer acquisition tools designed to attract new users and build trust in the platform.

Following the successful repayment of the first loan, borrowers would generally gain access to larger credit limits. At the same time, the cost of financing increased. According to numerous loan agreements, promotional materials, and borrower testimonials reviewed during this research, the pricing of repeat loans frequently began at approximately 2% per day. Using a simple annualized calculation, this corresponds to roughly 700% per annum, excluding the effects of compounding, penalties, and additional service charges.

Additional revenue could also be generated through a variety of service fees and ancillary charges. Depending on the company's business model, borrowers could be charged fees for application review, loan servicing, platform usage, consulting services, loan extensions, payment processing, and other related services. As a result, the effective cost of borrowing could differ substantially from the nominal interest rate disclosed in the underlying loan agreement.

From an economic perspective, the profitability of PDL operators was driven not only by interest income but also by the combination of recurring borrowing behavior, fee-based revenue streams, and the ability to automate much of the lending process through digital platforms and algorithmic scoring systems. This enabled lenders to process large volumes of relatively small loans while maintaining operational scalability.

At the same time, the model depended on a delicate balance between customer acquisition costs, default rates, collection efficiency, and pricing. Companies capable of accurately assessing borrower risk and effectively managing collections could potentially

achieve high returns despite elevated credit losses associated with serving financially underserved customer segments.

Example of Elevated Loan Charges: MoneyVeo

Document	Loan Amount	Total Repayment Amount	Additional Charges	Annualized Equivalent Rate*
Hồng Ân Thịnh Phát / MoneyVeo	6,200,000 VND	9,982,000 VND	3,782,000 VND	≈ 1,110–1,120% per annum

*The calculation was performed by the author by converting the aggregate contractual charges into an annualized rate equivalent and does not represent the company's official APR or regulatory disclosure.

Legal Structure of [MoneyVeo](#)

Legal Entity	Role	Registration Number
Hồng Ân Thịnh Phát Co., Ltd. (CÔNG TY TNHH HỒNG ÂN THỊNH PHÁT)	Lender / Pawnshop Operator, Issues the Loan	0316501210
Moneyveo Vietnam Co., Ltd. (CÔNG TY TNHH MONEYVEO VIỆT NAM)	Service Provider, Consulting, Data Processing, Loan Administration	0316182035
Hồng Ân Thịnh Phát Co., Ltd.	Custodian of Collateral Under the Asset Custody Agreement	0316501210

The loan agreement reviewed as part of this research identifies **CÔNG TY TNHH HỒNG ÂN THỊNH PHÁT** as the lender. The company is registered at 498/25 Nguyễn Văn Khỗi, Ward 9, Gò Vấp District, Ho Chi Minh City, and is managed by director **Lê Đỗ Hồng Ân**.

The service agreement identifies **Moneyveo Vietnam Co., Ltd.** as the service provider. The company is located at 21 Nguyễn Trung Ngạn, Bến Nghé Ward, District 1, Ho Chi Minh City, and is managed by director **Olena Andronikova**.

Particularly noteworthy is the fact that the service agreement explicitly states: “*Bên cho vay / đối tác cho vay tại thời điểm này là Công ty TNHH Hồng Ân Thịnh Phát.*” (“The lender / lending partner at this time is Hồng Ân Thịnh Phát Co., Ltd.”)

In other words, MoneyVeo expressly identifies **CÔNG TY TNHH HỒNG ÂN THỊNH PHÁT** as its lending partner.

From a structural perspective, the arrangement appears to operate as follows: The customer interacts with **Moneyveo Vietnam**, which performs marketing, customer acquisition, credit scoring, data processing, loan administration, and potentially fee-generating service activities. The loan application is then referred to **CÔNG TY TNHH HỒNG ÂN THỊNH PHÁT**, which acts as the formal lender under a pawnshop license and disburses the loan. The collateral custody agreement is also executed through **Hồng Ân Thịnh Phát Co., Ltd.**

At the same time, the pledged asset generally remains in the possession of the borrower, as the loan is issued remotely through an online process without requiring the customer to physically visit a branch or transfer possession of any asset.

This example illustrates what may be described as a legal separation of functions within the lending process. Different stages of customer acquisition, underwriting, loan issuance, collateral arrangements, servicing, and fee collection appear to be allocated among separate legal entities operating within the same overall business ecosystem.

The extent to which such arrangements comply with applicable Vietnamese laws and regulations falls outside the scope of this report. Nevertheless, the structure provides an example of how lending-related activities may be distributed among multiple entities while presenting borrowers with what appears to be a single integrated financial service.

The combination of high margins, scalable digital infrastructure, automated underwriting systems, and substantial unmet demand for short-term credit was one of the principal factors driving the rapid expansion of Vietnam's PDL market between 2015 and 2022.

Major Participants in Vietnam's Digital Micro-Lending Market

The table below summarizes a number of significant participants in Vietnam's digital payday lending (PDL) sector based on publicly available information reviewed during this investigation. The information reflects preliminary findings and should not be considered exhaustive. Certain corporate relationships, ownership structures, and management roles may require further independent verification.

Brand	Country / Jurisdiction of Group or Investment Origin	Vietnamese Legal Entity / Partner	Publicly Associated CEO / Executive	Verification Status
MoneyCat	Russia / international group with operations in Vietnam, the Philippines, and Russia	Lendtop / Saigon Credit / Alomo	Mikhail Soppa; previously Natalia Kovalenko	Public sources indicate links between MoneyCat, Saigon Credit, and Alomo
Robocash / UnaFinancial	Originated in Russia; later developed into an international structure with operations linked to Singapore and Europe	Robocash Vietnam / VietLoan	Sergey Sedov; Konstantin Bereutsky	Historical links to Robocash and Robot Zaymer are publicly documented
Moneyveo	Ukraine / Singapore-based holding company Moneyveo Asia	Moneyveo Vietnam Company Limited	Alyona (Olena) Andronikova	Singapore holding company established on 17 September 2019; Vietnamese entity established in 2020
VayVND	Not established; public references identify the Capital Solution brand	Capital Solution	No CEO identified in reliable public sources	Additional verification required
Takomo / Vay Xanh	Russia / Eqvanta Group (Bystrodengi, Turbozaim)	EIB ASIA / MANUTA	Ravil Aglyamov (reported as CEO in 2021); Marsel Zilyaev (subsequent	Supported by contractual documentation referencing EIB

			management period)	ASIA and MANUTA
Senmo	Lithuania / Aventus Group; also associated with Gofingo / Aventus Vietnam	Gofingo Vietnam / Aventus Vietnam	Vietnam CEO not identified	Public sources indicate links to Aventus Group
Tamo / Findo	Latvia / Sun Finance Group	Sofi Solutions / Digital Credit / Fincap VN	Aigars Plivčs; Sun Finance Group associated with Toms Jurjevs	Public reporting references regulatory and criminal proceedings in Vietnam concerning lending costs allegedly reaching up to 1,380% annually
OnCredit	Believed to be linked to Eastern Europe / Aventus Group	OnCredit Financial Investment Consulting Co., Ltd.	Tamara Horevchuanova (Ukraine)	Public traces of CPA affiliate offers and a Vietnamese legal entity have been identified
Doctor Dong / Cay Vang	Russia / Finstar Financial Group	LGC and related entities; possible market relationships with Saigon Credit and Safe Savings	Artem Andreev	One of the earliest and most established participants in Vietnam's digital lending sector

The companies listed above represent only a portion of the broader digital lending ecosystem that emerged in Vietnam between 2015 and 2026. Publicly available information suggests that many market participants operated through combinations of local Vietnamese entities, technology companies, consulting firms, pawnshop operators, financial-service intermediaries, and foreign holding structures.

In a number of cases, the separation of customer acquisition, credit scoring, loan issuance, servicing, collections, and technology functions across multiple legal entities appears to have formed a recurring operational pattern within the industry. However, the specific legal, operational, and ownership relationships between these entities may vary significantly from company to company and should be assessed individually.

The inclusion of any company, brand, executive, investor, or legal entity in this report should not be interpreted as evidence of unlawful conduct. All information is derived from publicly available sources and is presented solely for analytical and research purposes. Further verification may be required to confirm ownership structures, management roles, contractual relationships, and regulatory status.

5. Cashwagon as the First Major Public Case

Cashwagon began active operations in Vietnam around 2015–2016 as part of an international group developing digital lending services across Southeast Asia, including Vietnam, Indonesia, the Philippines, and Sri Lanka. According to [publicly available sources](#) and corporate publications, one of the key founders of the group's international business was **Maxim Chernushenko**.

Cashwagon was among the first companies in Vietnam to deploy a fully digital short-term lending model on a large scale, allowing borrowers to obtain loans online without visiting a physical office or branch. The company positioned itself as a modern fintech platform serving customers who, for various reasons, were unable to obtain traditional bank financing due to a lack of credit history, formal employment, or verifiable income.

The loan application process was designed to be highly streamlined. Customers were typically required to upload a photograph of their national identification document (CMND or CCCD), provide a mobile phone number and bank account details, after which the system would automatically evaluate the application using internal credit-scoring algorithms.

By 2020, the company's activities had attracted the attention of Vietnamese law enforcement authorities. In June 2020, Ho Chi Minh City police launched an investigation involving **Cashwagon Co., Ltd.** and **Lendtech Co., Ltd.** The case received significant media coverage, including reporting by the Singapore-based publication [Mothership](#).

According to publicly reported information regarding the investigation, Cashwagon was registered as a company providing financial consulting and technology-related services through online channels. Loan issuance, however, was reportedly conducted through

Lendtech Co., Ltd., a company possessing licenses associated with pawnshop-related activities.

According to investigative materials cited in public reports, the two companies appeared to have maintained a clear functional division of responsibilities. Cashwagon was reportedly responsible for customer acquisition, collection of personal information, credit scoring, preliminary lending decisions, and borrower servicing. Information was then transferred to **Lendtech Co., Ltd.**, which formally acted as the contracting party to the loan agreement.

Particular attention was reportedly directed toward the revenue structure associated with the lending model. Publicly available reports suggested that the effective cost of borrowing could reach approximately 22–44% per month after taking into account additional fees and service charges. According to information from market participants, initial loans were often offered on promotional terms or with no interest charges, while subsequent loans could carry costs broadly comparable to approximately 2% per day.

These statements are based on market sources and public reporting. They do not appear to have been formally established in court proceedings and should be regarded as requiring independent verification.

Following the launch of the investigation, a number of foreign online lenders reportedly reduced their public visibility in Vietnam or reassessed their corporate structures. According to reporting by [VietnamNet](#), many market participants increasingly adopted arrangements involving multiple legal entities, local representatives, and positioning themselves as technology platforms, intermediaries, or consulting providers rather than directly presenting themselves as lenders.

The same reporting noted that some online lenders allegedly utilized dual-registration business structures. Companies could be registered through local nominee representatives, operate multiple legal entities simultaneously, and describe themselves as technology platforms or intermediary services rather than credit providers.

Challenges surrounding Cashwagon also emerged in other jurisdictions where the group operated. In Sri Lanka, the company's activities were effectively suspended in 2020 following increased scrutiny from the Central Bank of Sri Lanka and local media organizations. The publication [Daily Mirror](#) reported that Cashwagon had stopped accepting new loan applications, while company representatives described the interruption as a temporary suspension of operations. At the same time, the Central Bank

of Sri Lanka issued public warnings regarding online lending applications that collected extensive amounts of personal user data.

It is also noteworthy that Cashwagon is not explicitly referenced in the current public LinkedIn profile of [Maxim Chernushenko](#). The period from April 2017 through December 2020 is described as service as **Founder & CEO of a Pan-Asian Fintech Project**. Subsequently, Mr. Chernushenko became associated with the [Fingular](#) group of companies, which develops digital lending projects including **Ammana** in Indonesia, [Tambadana](#) and [Ahapay](#) in Malaysia, and [TrastPaisa](#) in India.

At the time of preparing this report, the author was unable to identify publicly available information confirming a final criminal conviction of Cashwagon management, a court decision concluding the investigation, or a judicially ordered liquidation of the company. Following extensive media coverage during the summer of 2020, public references to the investigation became significantly less frequent. Later market reports generally referred only to the fact that Cashwagon had been the subject of review by Vietnamese law enforcement authorities.

Regardless of the ultimate outcome of the investigation, the Cashwagon case became one of the earliest public signals to regulators regarding the existence of complex corporate structures within the digital lending industry. The case contributed significantly to increased regulatory attention toward Vietnam's payday lending sector and helped shape subsequent discussions concerning consumer protection, licensing structures, and the supervision of online lending platforms.

6. International Assessment of the Issue (United Kingdom Government Report)

An analytical report published by the Government of the United Kingdom, entitled "[Vietnam: Fear of Illegal Money Lenders](#)" notes that illegal lending and so-called "black credit" continue to represent a significant issue in Vietnam. The report states that only licensed financial institutions operating under the supervision of the State Bank of Vietnam are legally authorized to provide lending services, while high-interest lending conducted outside the established regulatory framework is considered unlawful.

The authors of the report identify various forms of illegal lending, ranging from small local lenders to more organized structures allegedly connected to criminal groups. The report further emphasizes that illegal lending remains a socially significant issue and continues to attract the attention of Vietnamese law-enforcement authorities.

Of particular interest is the report's observation that illegal lending activities are frequently associated with complex organizational arrangements and, in some cases, debt collection practices involving threats, psychological pressure, and other forms of coercion aimed at securing repayment. At the same time, the existence of such practices is viewed by the report's authors as evidence of the continued presence of a substantial shadow-credit market within Vietnam.

The report also highlights the broader economic and social factors contributing to the persistence of informal lending networks, including limited access to formal credit among certain segments of the population, urgent short-term financing needs, and gaps in financial inclusion. These conditions create opportunities for both regulated and unregulated lending providers to expand their presence within the market.

Importantly, the report does not focus on any specific fintech company or lending platform. Rather, it examines the phenomenon of illegal lending as a broader structural issue affecting Vietnam's financial system and consumer protection environment. Consequently, the findings should be understood as a macro-level assessment rather than evidence concerning any individual company or market participant.

Taken together, the report demonstrates that concerns surrounding high-risk and insufficiently regulated lending activities in Vietnam have received international attention and are considered by foreign governmental institutions to be a relevant factor when assessing the country's social, economic, and regulatory environment. The report further suggests that the evolution of Vietnam's consumer lending market remains a subject of interest not only to domestic regulators but also to international policymakers, researchers, and organizations monitoring financial inclusion and consumer protection issues.

7. Regulatory Pressure and Criminal Cases

The investigation involving Cashwagon and Lendtech was not an isolated incident. Between 2022 and 2024, Vietnam's Ministry of Public Security (MPS), the Ho Chi Minh City Police, and regional law-enforcement agencies conducted a series of large-scale enforcement campaigns targeting segments of the digital micro-lending market.

It is important to note that regulatory and law-enforcement attention was driven not only by concerns regarding high lending costs and interest rates, but also by a substantial number of borrower complaints relating to debt collection practices. According to publicly reported information, authorities received allegations involving aggressive collection tactics, repeated communications with borrowers and their personal contacts,

dissemination of personal information, psychological pressure, and other practices that were perceived by complainants as coercive or abusive.

As a result, enforcement efforts increasingly focused not only on the pricing of loan products but also on the operational methods employed by lending platforms, affiliated service providers, debt collection agencies, and other entities involved in the consumer lending process. Investigations often examined the relationships between technology companies, consulting firms, marketing entities, collection operators, and formally licensed lending organizations in order to determine how responsibilities were allocated across different legal entities.

The period from 2022 to 2024 therefore marked a significant shift in regulatory scrutiny. Rather than concentrating solely on lending activity itself, authorities increasingly evaluated the broader ecosystem surrounding digital consumer credit, including customer acquisition practices, personal data processing, debt collection procedures, corporate structures, and the use of intermediary entities within lending operations.

The enforcement actions undertaken during this period contributed to a more cautious operating environment for digital lenders and increased pressure on market participants to review their business models, compliance frameworks, and organizational structures. They also highlighted the growing importance of consumer protection, data privacy, and responsible lending standards within Vietnam’s rapidly evolving digital finance sector.

Selected Enforcement Actions, Criminal Investigations, and Regulatory Cases Related to Vietnam’s Digital Lending Market

The following table summarizes publicly reported investigations, criminal cases, enforcement actions, and media reports reviewed during this research. The information presented below reflects allegations, findings, or statements reported by law-enforcement authorities and media organizations at the time of publication. Inclusion in this report should not be interpreted as proof of guilt or as evidence of a final judicial determination unless explicitly stated.

Brand / Company	Article / Report	Key Findings Reported
Cashwagon / Lendtech	Mothership: Vietnam Police Investigate Cashwagon and Lendtech	In June 2020, Ho Chi Minh City police investigated Cashwagon Co., Ltd. and Lendtech Co., Ltd. Individuals mentioned in public reporting included Nguyen Thi Thuy Hang (CEO of Cashwagon Vietnam), Chau

		Minh Quang (Lendtech representative), and Nguyen Tuyet Hoa (Director of Lendtech). According to reported investigative materials, Cashwagon handled customer acquisition, scoring, and loan servicing, while Lendtech acted as the formal lender through a pawnshop-based structure.
ATM Online / TM24H	Loan-Sharking Group in District 4 Earned VND 4.6 Trillion	Russian citizen Vladimir Verevkin, identified in reporting as Regional Director Vietnam, was arrested. Authorities reported approximately 738,933 loans totaling around VND 3.958 trillion, with repayments exceeding VND 4.627 trillion. Companies mentioned included ATM Online and TM24H.
Sun Finance	Latvian Man Investigated for Masterminding Loan Shark Ring in Vietnam	Latvian citizen Aigars Plivčs was identified as a subject of investigation. Authorities reported more than 6.8 million loans issued through the Tamo and Findo brands. Group revenue was reportedly estimated at approximately VND 4 trillion. Authorities alleged effective lending costs ranging from 401.5% to 1,379.7% annually.
Vaytocdo / Moreloan / VD Online	Saigon Police Bust Chinese-Led Ring Operating Loan Shark Apps with Over 60,000 Debtors	Individuals identified in reporting included Tu Long and Yuan Deng Hui. Authorities reported that the Vaytocdo, Moreloan, and VD Online applications had served more than 60,000 borrowers. Effective lending costs allegedly reached 1,095% annually.
Chinese Loan Applications	Chinese, Vietnamese Suspects Nabbed for Loan-Sharking on Mobile Apps	Authorities reported that Chinese and Vietnamese organizers used mobile applications to provide short-term loans. After delinquency, charges allegedly increased to levels equivalent to approximately 4% per day.
Unspecified Brand	Ukrainian-Led Loan Shark Operation with 2,000% Annual Interest	Authorities arrested two Ukrainian citizens accused of operating online lending services through applications and websites. Investigators alleged effective lending costs reaching up to 2,000% annually.
Wang Yun Tao Group	Chinese Loan Shark Who Charged 8.550% Interest Jailed for 33 Months	Chinese citizen Wang Yun Tao was sentenced to 33 months of imprisonment. Authorities and the court concluded that

		effective lending costs had reached approximately 8,550% annually.
Phuc Loc Tho Group	Russian Detained for Running Loan Shark Ring in Ho Chi Minh City	Russian citizen Maksim Zubkov was detained. Authorities associated the investigation with companies including Phuc Loc Tho, Bao Tin Kim Long, Gofigo, Infobot, Infinity, and Solution Lab.
Phuc Loc Tho Group	Six Loansharking Firms Raided in HCMC, 22 Arrested	Twenty-two individuals were detained during enforcement actions. Authorities reported activities involving Phuc Loc Tho, Bao Tin Kim Long, Gofigo, Infobot, Infinity, and Solution Lab. Effective lending costs allegedly reached 2,555% annually.
Quang Ninh Loan Group	Quang Ninh Police Bust Loan Shark Operation with 360% Annual Interest	Authorities identified Do Minh Tu as the alleged organizer. More than 9,000 lending transactions were reportedly uncovered. Rates allegedly reached approximately 30% per month, or 360% annually. iCloud account information was reportedly used as part of the collateral arrangement.
Loan App Collections	Loan Sharks Terrorize Debtors with Few Keyboard Strokes in Ho Chi Minh City	Tuoi Tre described practices involving access to borrower contact lists, mass calling campaigns targeting relatives and acquaintances, threats, and psychological pressure. Reports also referenced the use of iCloud and phonebook data obtained from borrowers.
Nude Loan Ring	Vietnam Police Break Up Loan Shark Ring Demanding Nude Photos as Collateral	Individuals identified in reporting included Luong Minh Ngoc and Nguyen Thai Quy. Authorities alleged that photographs and videos of an intimate nature were used as collateral. Lending costs were reported at approximately 180–365% annually.
F88	Reuters: Police Raid F88 Pawnshop Chain	Authorities conducted inspections and investigative actions involving Vietnam's largest pawnshop chain, F88. Public reporting referenced collection practices, fees, and potential allegations relating to coercive conduct.
Market-Wide Enforcement	Protect Workers from Loan Sharks: PM	Prime Minister Pham Minh Chinh instructed the State Bank of Vietnam (SBV), the Ministry

		of Public Security (MPS), and other agencies to strengthen efforts against illegal lending and improve borrower protection.
Market-Wide Enforcement	Vietnam Police Bust Loan Shark Rings Charging Yearly Interest of up to 720%	Authorities dismantled two lending groups and reported effective lending costs reaching approximately 720% annually. Around 500 borrowers were reportedly identified as affected.
Market-Wide Enforcement	Vietnam News Investigation	Vietnam News reported on lending applications where effective borrowing costs allegedly reached between 1,000% and 2,000% annually. Articles also discussed alleged use of consulting entities, intermediary structures, and regulatory-avoidance mechanisms involving entities positioned between borrowers and lenders.

Taken collectively, these cases suggest that Vietnamese authorities increasingly focused not only on the level of lending charges but also on the broader operational structures supporting digital lending activities. Public investigations frequently examined relationships among technology providers, consulting firms, pawnshop operators, marketing entities, debt collection organizations, and lending companies.

While the facts and outcomes varied significantly from case to case, a recurring theme in public reporting was the use of multiple legal entities to separate customer acquisition, scoring, loan issuance, servicing, collections, and fee generation. This pattern became one of the central issues attracting the attention of regulators, law-enforcement agencies, policymakers, and consumer-protection advocates during the period under review.

According to [FiinGroup](#), many fintech lending applications operate primarily as marketing, customer acquisition, processing, and servicing channels throughout the digital lending lifecycle, while the actual loan agreements are executed through pawnshop entities that serve as the formal lending counterparties.

FiinGroup specifically references brands including **Doctor Dong** (subsequently rebranded as **Cay Vang**), **MoneyCat**, and **One Click**. This report is of particular relevance to the present research because it supports the existence of an operating model in which a digital lending platform functions in conjunction with a company holding a pawnshop license.

From an investigative perspective, the significance of this finding extends beyond the analysis of individual brands. If lending-related functions are distributed among multiple entities, examination of the public-facing fintech platform alone may provide only a partial view of the overall structure. A comprehensive assessment may therefore require consideration of all entities involved in the lending process, including those responsible for customer acquisition, credit assessment, loan origination, payment processing, servicing, collections, and related operational functions.

The FiinGroup analysis is particularly noteworthy because it originates from a recognized Vietnamese financial research and analytics organization rather than from media reporting, borrower complaints, or market participants. As such, it provides an independent analytical perspective on structural characteristics observed within segments of Vietnam's digital lending market.

At the same time, the report does not conclude that the use of a fintech platform together with a pawnshop-licensed entity is, by itself, unlawful. Rather, it highlights a business model that appears to have been present in portions of the market and that may warrant closer examination by regulators, researchers, and other stakeholders seeking to understand the allocation of responsibilities, revenues, risks, and regulatory obligations among participating entities.

Viewed together with the contractual examples and public investigations discussed earlier in this report, the FiinGroup findings may be interpreted as further evidence that analysis of Vietnam's digital lending sector should extend beyond individual consumer-facing brands and include the broader network of affiliated legal entities involved in loan origination, customer servicing, fund flows, collateral arrangements, and debt collection activities.

8. Collections and Social Consequences

The most profitable stage of the loan lifecycle for a lender often becomes delinquent debt. When a borrower fails to make payment on time, penalties, additional fees, and daily overdue charges may be applied. Analysis of publicly available agreements indicates that, in certain cases, such charges may reach 2–3% of the total outstanding obligation.

A separate role is played by loan extension mechanisms. If a customer is unable to fully repay the debt by the due date, they may be offered the option of paying a portion of the accrued interest and fees in exchange for extending the repayment date. Formally, such a mechanism helps avoid immediate default. In practice, however, it often leads to

situations in which borrowers continue paying fees and additional charges for extended periods without significantly reducing the principal amount of the debt.

The economic attractiveness of this model is explained by several factors. First, the high cost of financing made it possible to offset a substantial proportion of defaults and non-performing loans. Second, the fully digital operating model significantly reduced operating expenses compared to traditional bank branches. Third, automated credit scoring and remote loan issuance allowed companies to scale their business with little proportional increase in staffing levels.

Even with relatively high delinquency rates, the overall profitability of loan portfolios could remain attractive to investors. According to market participants, the loan portfolios of major operators could reach USD 10–20 million. With charges at approximately 2% per day, the theoretical daily accruals on such portfolios could amount to hundreds of thousands of U.S. dollars before accounting for defaults, reserves, funding costs, marketing expenses, and operating expenditures.

Particular concern within this model arises from the fact that many mobile lending applications obtained access to significant volumes of borrowers' personal data. In addition to identification documents and phone numbers, borrowers frequently granted applications access to contact lists, device information, geolocation data, SMS messages, and other elements of their digital profile. Formally, such access was often justified as necessary for credit scoring and customer identification. However, these same data sets could subsequently be used during debt collection activities.

Unlike traditional banking, where delinquent debt management is generally limited to formal notices, restructuring negotiations, and legal proceedings, some participants in the online lending market reportedly employed substantially more aggressive collection practices. Following delinquency, borrowers could receive dozens of phone calls and messages each day through call centers, SMS, WhatsApp, Zalo, Telegram, and other communication channels. In many cases, pressure was reportedly directed not only at the borrower but also at relatives, friends, colleagues, and employers.

One of the most controversial practices involved the use of contacts extracted from the borrower's phonebook. According to investigations and media reports, collection personnel could conduct mass calling campaigns targeting individuals known to the borrower, disclose the existence of outstanding debts, send repayment demands, and employ various forms of psychological pressure.

In reporting by [VietnamNet](#), representatives of the Hanoi police specifically referred to cases involving threats, misuse of personal data, and pressure placed on borrowers' relatives. Such practices were particularly sensitive in Asian societies, where family reputation and social standing often play an important role. For many debtors, the primary concern was not the size of the debt itself but the risk of public embarrassment before family members, colleagues, and neighbors.

[Channel News Asia](#) described a case in Vietnam in which relatives of a borrower reportedly received more than 30 collection calls per day. According to the publication, following delinquency, manipulated photographs of the borrower's family members accompanied by humiliating comments were allegedly distributed through social media channels. As a result, the borrower reportedly closed his business in an effort to end the pressure placed on his family.

It was against the backdrop of such complaints that Vietnamese authorities initiated investigations into dozens of mobile lending applications. Among the most widely publicized cases were Vaytocdo, Moreloan, and VD Online. According to police statements, these applications formed part of the infrastructure of larger groups associated with Russian, Eastern European, and Chinese organizers active in the online lending sector. Investigative materials reported that, after taking into account fees, penalties, and additional charges, the effective cost of borrowing could reach the equivalent of approximately 900–1,300% per annum.

By 2021–2023, it had become increasingly clear that the government's response was not directed solely at a single company such as Cashwagon, but rather at the broader ecosystem of high-risk digital lending. The cases involving ATM Online, Moreloan, VD Online, and similar services demonstrated that Vietnamese authorities viewed the issue as extending far beyond individual brands. Regulatory and law-enforcement attention increasingly focused on the underlying business model itself—a model characterized by high borrowing costs, complex and often opaque fee structures, extensive use of borrowers' personal data, and aggressive debt collection practices.

9. The 2024–2025 Paradox: The Market Did Not Disappear

At first glance, it might have appeared that the large-scale investigations conducted between 2022 and 2024 would lead to the disappearance of Vietnam's digital micro-lending market. Law-enforcement agencies carried out raids, criminal cases were initiated, mobile applications were shut down, and organizers of certain schemes were detained. However, subsequent developments demonstrated that government pressure

primarily affected the most visible and aggressive market participants, while failing to eliminate the underlying economic factors that supported the business model itself.

An analysis of publicly available information indicates that a significant portion of the major participants in Vietnam's payday lending (PDL) sector have foreign origins in terms of capital, technology, management teams, or operational expertise. As a result, the market represents not only a domestic Vietnamese phenomenon but also part of a broader transnational alternative lending industry connecting investors, technology developers, and management teams from multiple countries.

The infrastructure supporting many such projects is often highly distributed. Software development and credit-scoring systems may be operated outside Vietnam, while marketing activities and customer acquisition may be organized through international networks of partners and contractors. Call centers and operational teams may be located within Vietnam, while legal entities holding intellectual property rights or providing service functions may be incorporated in Singapore, Hong Kong, or other international financial jurisdictions.

Such a multi-layered organizational structure significantly complicates efforts to identify ultimate beneficial owners, sources of financing, and the ultimate recipients of profits. The legal entity formally interacting with borrowers inside Vietnam does not necessarily reveal where strategic decisions are made, who owns the underlying technology platform, who controls credit policy, or in which jurisdiction the majority of economic value is ultimately concentrated.

Following the enforcement actions of 2022–2024, demand for short-term loans did not disappear. A substantial segment of the population continued to face limited access to traditional banking products. For many individuals, obtaining a bank loan remained too complex, too slow, or simply inaccessible due to the absence of formal employment, documented income, an established credit history, or sufficient financial documentation. At the same time, demand for small short-term loans remained persistent. Borrowers continued to require funds for rent, medical expenses, motorbike repairs, education costs, groceries, repayment of existing debts, or temporary cash-flow shortages before receiving their salaries.

For lenders, the PDL model continued to offer strong economic incentives. Automated credit scoring, digital customer acquisition, remote loan issuance, and relatively high financing costs allowed market participants to generate substantial gross returns even in the presence of elevated delinquency rates. Unlike traditional banks, these companies did not require expensive branch networks, and core business processes could be scaled

through mobile applications, call centers, affiliate-marketing funnels, and payment infrastructure.

As a result, the investigations did not eliminate the market so much as reshape it. The most aggressive, poorly structured, and legally vulnerable operators either exited the market or became targets of criminal investigations. However, the resulting market opportunities were gradually filled by other participants employing more cautious positioning strategies and more sophisticated legal structures.

It was precisely after 2022 that brands such as Doctor Dong, later associated by market participants with Cay Vang, along with MoneyCat, Takomo (Vay Xanh), Senmo, OnCredit, VayVND, Moneyveo, Robocash/UnaFinancial, Tamo, and Findo continued operating or expanded their presence. These companies differed in origin, ownership structures, legal frameworks, and levels of public visibility. Nevertheless, their continued development reflected a common trend: demand for short-term digital lending persisted, and the industry adapted to a changing regulatory environment.

One important change involved public positioning. During the early years of the market, many participants openly described themselves as fintech platforms or online lenders. After 2022, however, companies increasingly adopted more neutral terminology, describing themselves as “financial platforms,” “consulting services,” “technology intermediaries,” “financial-service marketplaces,” “financial assistants,” or “loan comparison platforms.” Such terminology allowed brands to distance themselves from direct lending activity and potentially reduce regulatory exposure.

As a result, some newer market participants—as well as companies that survived the Cashwagon era and subsequent investigations—underwent visible transformations. They increasingly relied on more complex legal structures, exercised greater caution in describing their products publicly, and sought to avoid presenting themselves as direct lenders. Yet a closer examination often reveals similar underlying characteristics: digital borrower acquisition, preliminary credit scoring, short-term lending products, significant service charges, distribution of functions across multiple entities, and a substantial reliance on marketing infrastructure.

For this reason, the period between 2022 and 2024 should be viewed not as the end of Vietnam’s PDL market but rather as the beginning of a structural transformation. Government pressure did not eliminate the economic foundations of short-term digital lending. Instead, it encouraged market participants to modify legal structures, redistribute operational functions, develop more complex contractual arrangements, and adopt a more cautious approach to public positioning.

This is the central paradox of the period under review. The state successfully targeted some of the most visible and aggressive market participants, yet demand for short-term credit remained intact. Alongside that demand, the economic attractiveness of the business model also persisted. Consequently, the market did not disappear; rather, it entered a new phase of development in which competitive advantage depended not only on the speed of loan issuance but also on a company's ability to adapt legally and organizationally to an increasingly stringent regulatory environment.

10. The Role of Infrastructure in Microfinance Operations

A natural question arises: why did some companies disappear following the investigations, while others remained active and continued to develop? An analysis of corporate structures, publicly available agreements, mobile application descriptions, and market practices makes it possible to identify several adaptation mechanisms that may have been employed by market participants after 2023.

The first mechanism was the legal fragmentation of business functions. Rather than concentrating all activities within a single company, market participants increasingly distributed different stages of the lending process across multiple legal entities. One company could be responsible for marketing and customer acquisition, another for data processing and credit scoring, a third for executing loan agreements, a fourth for collecting service fees, and a fifth for debt collection activities. To the borrower, the transaction appeared to be a simple online loan, while legally it could be divided across multiple contracts and multiple companies.

The second mechanism involved the use of pawnshop licenses and broker-based models. Instead of operating through conventional consumer lending structures, some companies arranged transactions through entities associated with pawnshop activities. Formally, the loan could be structured as being secured by property such as a mobile phone, motorbike, or another asset. However, in some models, physical transfer of the asset may have been absent or replaced by digital or contractual arrangements. For example, a customer could continue using the asset while simultaneously paying additional fees related to storage, rental, maintenance, or administration of the collateral.

Such a model allowed the transaction to be formally positioned outside the framework of traditional consumer lending and within a different legal regime. At the same time, the economic substance for the borrower could remain largely unchanged: the customer received a relatively small amount of money for a short period and was required to repay it with additional charges. For this reason, pawnshop-based models require separate analysis. It is important to examine whether real collateral existed, whether physical

transfer of property occurred, who controlled the asset, what fees were charged, and how the effective cost of borrowing was calculated.

The third mechanism involved shifting profitability away from nominal interest rates and into various fees and service charges. While regulators often focus on stated interest rates, some companies could reduce the formal interest rate contained in the loan agreement while simultaneously increasing ancillary charges. Under such models, a substantial portion of profitability could be generated through service fees, consulting fees, processing fees, rental fees, extension fees, overdue fees, digital servicing charges, and other categories of payments.

As a result, the formal interest rate could appear relatively moderate while the actual cost of borrowing for the customer was significantly higher. For example, a borrower might see a low interest rate in the primary agreement while simultaneously being required to pay for consulting services, platform services, loan extensions, asset rental arrangements, or payment-processing services. Economically, these charges could form part of the overall cost of credit, while legally they might be distributed across separate agreements and different legal entities.

The fourth mechanism was the gradual abandonment of the direct term “lender” in public communications. After 2023, many market participants became noticeably more cautious in describing their products. Instead of using terms such as “loan,” “lender,” “credit company,” or “microfinance institution,” companies increasingly adopted more neutral descriptions such as “financial assistant,” “digital financial platform,” “loan comparison platform,” “consulting service,” “technology partner,” or “financial solution.”

Such language reduced the direct association with lending activities and created the impression that the company was providing information, technology, or intermediary services rather than credit itself. For market analysis, however, the key consideration is not the wording used in marketing materials but the company’s actual role within the lending chain. Relevant questions include whether the company acquires customers, collects personal data, participates in credit scoring, influences lending decisions, receives commissions, manages loan extensions, or participates in debt collection activities.

The fifth mechanism was the development of marketplaces and affiliate-driven acquisition funnels. As regulatory attention increasingly focused on direct lenders, greater importance was assumed by platforms that did not themselves issue loans but specialized in attracting borrowers. These platforms purchased advertising through Facebook, Google Ads, TikTok, SEO websites, CPA networks, and other

performance-marketing channels, collected applications, and distributed them to various lending companies.

Such platforms could position themselves as independent comparison services or aggregators of financial products. In practice, however, they often became critical components of the PDL ecosystem because they controlled borrower acquisition. A single application could be distributed to multiple lenders, increasing the likelihood of multiple borrowing relationships and potentially contributing to borrower over-indebtedness.

As a result, by 2025–2026 Vietnam’s digital micro-lending market had become substantially more complex than during the emergence of its earliest participants. Simple direct-lending models increasingly gave way to multi-layered structures involving fintech brands, consulting companies, pawnshops, affiliate platforms, scoring providers, payment intermediaries, and debt-collection operations.

For this reason, modern analysis of the market cannot be limited to a single mobile application or a single legal entity. It is necessary to examine the entire value chain: who acquires the customer, who collects personal data, who makes the lending decision, who formally issues the loan, who receives commissions, who manages loan extensions, who conducts collections, and who ultimately receives the economic benefits generated by the transaction.

The persistence of Vietnam’s PDL market after 2023 can largely be explained by this capacity for adaptation. Companies that were unable to modify their business models and continued operating in highly visible and legally vulnerable forms often became targets of raids and criminal investigations. By contrast, participants that successfully redistributed functions, modified their legal structures, developed more complex contractual arrangements, and integrated themselves into broader fintech infrastructure were able to continue operating in a new phase of market development.

11. Doctor Dong / Cay Vang: One of the Leading Participants in Vietnam’s Micro-Lending Industry

The history of Doctor Dong is of particular interest for understanding the evolution of digital micro-lending companies in Vietnam. Unlike Cashwagon, which became the most widely known subject of a public investigation in 2020, Doctor Dong managed to maintain its market presence and continue operating after the period of most intensive scrutiny by law-enforcement authorities.

According to publicly available sources, Doctor Dong began actively developing its operations in Vietnam around 2015, almost simultaneously with the emergence of the first major participants in the digital lending sector. The company offered a fully remote model for issuing short-term loans through digital and mobile channels and quickly became one of the most recognizable brands in the payday lending (PDL) segment.

In subsequent years, Doctor Dong was repeatedly mentioned in market analyses of alternative lending, FiinGroup research reports, publications concerning the development of Vietnam’s fintech industry, and numerous borrower complaints relating to loan costs and debt collection practices.

Examples of Cay Vang Agreements (formerly Doctor Dong)

Document	Loan Amount	Total Repayment Amount	Additional Charges	Annualized Equivalent Rate*
Asset-lease-SA SA-signed + Pawn-Annex-S ASA-signed	1,000,000 VND	1,867,300 VND	867,300 VND	≈1,040–1,100% per annum

*The calculation was performed by the author by converting the aggregate contractual charges into an annualized rate equivalent and does not represent the company’s official APR or regulatory disclosure.

The contractual documentation reviewed during this research is noteworthy because it appears to illustrate a structure involving multiple legal agreements rather than a single conventional consumer-loan contract. The reviewed documents include an asset lease agreement and a pawn-related annex, suggesting the use of a legal framework that differs from a standard unsecured consumer loan.

From an analytical perspective, such arrangements may be relevant because they potentially separate the economic substance of the transaction from its formal legal structure. While the borrower receives funds and undertakes repayment obligations, different elements of the transaction may be allocated across multiple contractual documents and potentially multiple entities. As discussed in earlier sections of this report, similar approaches have been observed elsewhere in Vietnam’s digital lending market, particularly where pawnshop-based structures are involved.

Doctor Dong’s continued presence in the market after the regulatory actions of 2020–2024 is noteworthy because it suggests a degree of organizational adaptability.

While some market participants became subjects of criminal investigations or ceased operations, brands associated with the Doctor Dong/Cay Vang ecosystem continued to appear in market discussions, borrower reviews, and industry analyses.

This does not, by itself, imply compliance or non-compliance with applicable laws and regulations. However, it highlights an important feature of Vietnam's digital lending sector: the ability of certain participants to modify branding, legal structures, operational models, and public positioning while continuing to operate within the broader short-term lending ecosystem.

For this reason, the Doctor Dong/Cay Vang case is significant not only because of its size or longevity but also because it provides an opportunity to examine how digital lending businesses can evolve over time in response to changing regulatory expectations, enforcement actions, and market conditions. In this respect, the company serves as an illustrative example of the broader transformation that has taken place within Vietnam's PDL market during the last decade.

Particular attention should be paid to the reported connections between Doctor Dong and international investment structures operating in the microfinance sector across multiple jurisdictions. In various industry publications and corporate materials, the brand has been associated with the investment ecosystem of **Finstar Financial Group** and **Digital Finance International (DFI)**.

Finstar was founded by [Oleg Boyko](#), a Russian entrepreneur and investor known for his investments in consumer finance and micro-lending businesses. Over many years, entities associated with Finstar have invested in companies operating across Europe, India, the CIS region, Latin America, and Asia. Among the most widely known assets associated with the group at various points in time was **4Finance**, one of the largest online lending operators in Europe.

In a number of industry reports and corporate presentations, Doctor Dong (currently believed by some market participants to be associated with the Cay Vang brand) has been referenced as part of an international alternative lending ecosystem connected to investments from Finstar and DFI. At the same time, it should be noted that the ownership structure and allocation of corporate control require additional verification through corporate registries and official documentation.

Of particular interest is the author's hypothesis regarding the transformation of the Doctor Dong brand into Cay Vang. According to information circulating among market participants, part of the business may have continued operating under the Cay Vang

brand in 2024 following increased regulatory scrutiny and changes in market conditions, while utilizing infrastructure previously associated with Doctor Dong. However, the author has not identified publicly available documents that conclusively establish legal continuity between Doctor Dong and Cay Vang. Accordingly, this assumption should be treated solely as a working hypothesis requiring further verification.

During the course of this research, a corporate reference was identified relating to **FINWORLD LIMITED COMPANY (CÔNG TY TRÁCH NHIỆM HỮU HẠN FINWORLD)**, a company registered in Vietnam. Corporate records list **ILIN EGOR** as the legal representative of the company.

It is important to emphasize that the existence of this legal entity and the appearance of ILIN EGOR in corporate documentation do not, by themselves, constitute evidence of ownership or control of Doctor Dong or Cay Vang. Nevertheless, this information may be relevant as one element within a broader corporate ecosystem that could warrant additional examination.

According to corporate records reviewed during this research, **Artem Andreev** appeared at various times in the registration documents of **CÔNG TY TNHH MỘT THÀNH VIÊN TƯ VẤN TÀI CHÍNH LGC** in the capacity of **Chủ tịch Công ty** (Company Chairman) and was identified as a key executive associated with the operations of Doctor Dong in Vietnam.

Given his long-term presence within the management structure, involvement in contractual documentation, and references identifying him as **Country Manager Vietnam** within the international DFI group, Artem Andreev may be regarded as one of the principal managers within this corporate ecosystem.

At the same time, the author has not identified publicly available corporate documents confirming that Artem Andreev held an ownership interest in the charter capital of LGC or that he was the ultimate beneficial owner of the company. Accordingly, any assertions regarding direct ownership of LGC by Artem Andreev require additional documentary verification.

Particular attention should also be paid to the activities of the following legal entities, which appear in agreements, corporate documents, and public materials associated with the Doctor Dong and Cay Vang brands:

Legal Entity	Address	Legal Representative / Director	Main Area of Activity
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CÔNG TY TNHH MỘT THÀNH VIÊN TƯ VẤN TÀI CHÍNH LGC (NTNN)	3rd Floor, Lot C, 27B Nguyễn Đình Chiểu Building, Đa Kao Ward, District 1, Ho Chi Minh City	Artem Andreev appears in agreements as Chủ tịch; other representatives appeared in state registries during different periods	Financial consulting, borrower support, application processing, intermediary services in the lending sector
CÔNG TY TRÁCH NHIỆM HỮU HẠN TRỌNG TÍN AN (NTNN)	Ho Chi Minh City	Nguyễn Trọng Ngọc	Commercial activity; the actual role in the lending business requires further verification
CÔNG TY TNHH SAFE SAVINGS (NTNN)	563 Tân Sơn, Ward 12, Gò Vấp District, Ho Chi Minh City	Nguyễn Trọng Ngọc	Financial services; the company appears within a corporate ecosystem associated with digital lending
Công ty TNHH TMDV Hoàng An Phú	325A Điện Biên Phủ, Ward 15, Bình Thạnh District, Ho Chi Minh City	Dương Hữu Chinh	Pawnshop lending, issuance of loans secured by property, custody of pledged assets
FINWORLD LIMITED COMPANY (CÔNG TY TRÁCH NHIỆM HỮU HẠN FINWORLD)	Ho Chi Minh City	Egor Ilin (ILIN EGOR)	Requires further verification; allegedly financial and technology services

It may also be relevant to verify the actual number of employees employed by the above-mentioned companies, in particular **FINWORLD LIMITED COMPANY (CÔNG TY TRÁCH NHIỆM HỮU HẠN FINWORLD)**, as well as their management structure, the presence of foreign employees and executives, the legal basis for obtaining work permits and Temporary Residence Cards (TRC), and compliance with Vietnam's labor, migration, and tax regulations.

According to the organizational structure identified during the research, the following individuals were associated with various operational functions within the company: Artem Andreev (Country Manager), Vladimir Borisov (Finance Manager), Andrey Kudinov

(Product Manager), Vu Nguyen Dang (Tax Manager responsible for contractual relations with the police), Alina Shafagutdinova (HR), Bich Huynh Thi Ngoc (Manager), Hieu Le Huu (HR), Nguyen Cao Thanh Nhan (HR), Oleg Nem (Manager), Nguyen Viet Quynh (Manager), Huy Hua (Manager), NI Ha Quoc (Manager), Dung Dang Thi Thuy (Manager), Dung Ngo Hoang (Manager), and Chinh Duong Huu (Manager).

According to the available information, these individuals interacted within the HR, Collection, IT, Legal, Finance, Product, and Quality Control functions. Particular attention may be warranted with respect to personnel responsible for debt collection, information technology, financial operations, HR support for foreign employees, and interaction with Vietnamese government authorities, as these functions are directly related to the operation and administration of a digital lending platform within Vietnam.

Additional examination may be warranted regarding the allocation of functions among affiliated parties, the actual location where business activities are conducted, the application of double taxation avoidance agreements, the payment of Personal Income Tax (PIT) by foreign employees and managers, and the extent to which the activities performed comply with Vietnamese legislation governing consumer lending, financial intermediation, personal data processing, and debt collection.

At the time of preparing this report, Cay Vang remains one of the most visible brands in Vietnam's short-term digital micro-lending sector and represents an example of how certain market participants have managed to maintain operations following a period of intensified regulatory scrutiny and enforcement activity.

12. Takomo / Vay Xanh as a Lender with Charges Equivalent to 785–943% per Annum

Among all of the market participants examined, Takomo (believed to have subsequently transformed into the Vay Xanh brand) is of particular interest from the perspective of documentary analysis of transaction structures. Unlike most companies, whose operations must be analyzed through indirect indicators, in the case of Takomo it was possible to obtain a set of interconnected documents relating to the same lending transaction.

Takomo (EIB ASIA) *(Believed to be operating under the Vay Xanh brand as of 2026)*

Document	Loan Amount	Total Repayment Amount	Additional Charges	Annualized Equivalent Rate*
EIB ASIA / MANUTA	500,000 VND	607,500 VND after 10 days of delinquency; 887,500 VND after 30 days of delinquency	107,500–387,500 VND	≈ 785–943% per annum

*The calculation was performed by the author by converting the aggregate contractual charges into an annualized rate equivalent and does not represent the company's official APR or regulatory disclosure.

From publicly available sources, we were able to establish that Takomo (presumably transformed into Vay Xanh) entered the Vietnamese market in 2020 as a digital online lending platform. The main investments in the development of the business were reportedly provided by the Russian fintech group Eqvanta, one of the largest players in the microfinance market in Russia.

At the launch stage, the Vietnamese operation was reportedly headed by Ravil Aglyamov, who was responsible for business development, building the local team, and organizing the company's operational activities. In 2023, the position of CEO Vietnam was assumed by Marsel Zilyaev, under whose leadership the company continued to scale its operations, expand its customer base, and improve its internal processes.

According to publicly available sources, Alexander Guskov was responsible for product strategy and the development of customer services. His area of responsibility included the development of the product line, implementation of new functionalities, and adaptation of the business model to the specific characteristics of the Vietnamese market. The technology function and development of the IT infrastructure were supervised by Marat Gataullin. Under his leadership, the company ensured support of key information systems, development of the digital platform, integration of external services, and scaling of the company's technological infrastructure.

Thus, by 2026, Takomo (currently possibly Vay Xanh) had formed a management team in Vietnam that combined specialists with experience in Russian fintech and international online lending, allowing the company to develop a fully digital lending model in one of the most dynamic markets in Southeast Asia.

However, the main danger of such activities lies not only in the high cost of loans offered to Vietnamese citizens, but also in the mechanism through which a persistent credit

dependency may be formed among the most financially vulnerable segments of the population. Unlike traditional bank lending, where a customer usually undergoes a comprehensive assessment of creditworthiness and receives a clear repayment schedule, the short-term online lending market is primarily targeted at people who urgently need money and who are already in a difficult life situation.

As a rule, a person needs a relatively small amount of money, equivalent to approximately USD 100–200. These funds may be required for rent, medical treatment, motorbike repairs, food purchases, school expenses for a child, or repayment of another debt. However, many online lenders do not provide a new customer with the full amount required. The first loan is often limited to the equivalent of USD 20–30. From the perspective of the risk model, this allows the company to test the customer's repayment behavior and reduce the probability of an immediate default. For the borrower, however, an entirely different situation arises.

If a person objectively needs USD 150 and one company is willing to provide only USD 25, he begins searching for money through other applications. As a result, the borrower may simultaneously obtain loans from several services. For example, part of the required amount may be obtained from Money Cat, another part from Takomo (Vay Xanh), followed by applications to Doctor Dong (Cay Vang) and VayVND. Formally, each individual loan appears small and manageable. In reality, however, the customer begins living with multiple short-term obligations at the same time, each having different repayment dates, different fees, different extension rules, and different penalties.

At the initial stage, such a model appears safe to the borrower. Many applications actively use the marketing strategy of a first loan at 0% interest or without interest for 7–10 days. For a person who urgently needs money, this creates the perception of temporary financial assistance rather than a high-cost credit product. The borrower assumes that the money will be repaid quickly after receiving a salary and that no problems will arise.

However, it is precisely at this point that credit dependency begins to develop. The person receives a positive first experience with the platform. He repays the first loan on time and begins to perceive the service as a convenient and safe tool. After that, the company offers a second loan for a larger amount, for example 1,000,000 VND. At this stage, the borrower often stops carefully reviewing the terms because he has already developed psychological trust in the platform based on the successful first experience.

At the same time, the structure of charges becomes significantly more complex. In addition to the official interest rate, service fees, servicing charges, consulting payments, extension fees, and additional charges in the event of delinquency begin to appear. For an

ordinary person, this entire system appears highly non-transparent. The borrower may see only a daily rate of 0.1% or 2% per day in the application interface, without understanding what such charges translate into on a monthly or annual basis.

An additional danger is created by the loan extension mechanism. When a customer is unable to repay the entire amount in full, he is offered the option of paying only the extension fee instead of repaying the principal debt. To the borrower, this appears to be a temporary solution to the problem. For example, instead of repaying 3 million VND, he may be offered the possibility of paying only 400,000–600,000 VND, after which the loan term is automatically extended for several more weeks. Psychologically, this is perceived as easier than having to repay the entire amount immediately.

However, in practice, the principal debt does not decrease. The borrower begins making regular payments of fees while remaining inside the system. After several months, the total amount of service charges and fees paid may become comparable to the original loan amount or even exceed it. This is precisely how a debt cycle is gradually formed, in which the borrower is no longer able to exit the system without obtaining a new loan or purchasing another extension.

The situation becomes particularly difficult once delinquency occurs. If the customer misses a payment by even a few days, new charges begin to accumulate. In addition to official interest, one-time penalties, daily overdue fees, and additional service charges may be applied simultaneously. Some agreements and borrower complaints refer to charges at the level of 2–3% per day. For a financially inexperienced person, such figures may appear insignificant because they are perceived as “just a few percent.” However, over an extended delinquency period, such charges may develop into a debt burden that is effectively impossible to repay.

A serious problem is also created by the structure of the agreements themselves describing the credit products. For an ordinary borrower, it becomes almost impossible to understand who the actual lender is, which company receives the money, which payments are mandatory, and which are structured as separate services. A single transaction may simultaneously include a loan agreement, a consulting agreement, an asset rental agreement, and various service fees. For a person without legal or financial training, such a structure appears as a collection of formal documents whose meaning cannot be fully assessed.

An additional risk arises from the fact that advertising materials and application interfaces often do not display the full cost of the loan over the entire borrowing period. Instead, emphasis is placed on low daily charges, rapid approval, the absence of

supporting documentation requirements, and a “zero-interest rate” during the initial stage. The borrower may not see the effective cost of credit in the event of extensions or delinquency at all. As a result, the individual develops the perception that he is using a relatively inexpensive financial product, even though the actual cost of borrowing may reach hundreds or even thousands of percent per annum when calculated over a longer period.

The social danger of such models lies in the fact that they gradually create a segment of people who live permanently within a system of short-term debt. Particularly vulnerable are young borrowers, individuals with unstable incomes, residents of provincial areas, and citizens who lack access to traditional bank credit. For such individuals, digital loans cease to be a temporary solution to a problem and instead become a permanent source of financing for everyday life.

When such practices become widespread, there is a risk of increasing the overall debt burden of the population, weakening the financial stability of households, and increasing social tensions. This is why such models raise serious questions regarding lending transparency, consumer protection, disclosure of the full cost of credit, the permissibility of hidden fees, and the prevention of debt dependency among the population.

For this reason, Takomo (Vay Xanh) represents one of the most important cases for analyzing the modern architecture of Vietnam’s online lending market. The company makes it possible to examine, through a specific example, how financing processes, customer acquisition, loan servicing, and the allocation of different categories of payments among multiple legal entities may be organized within a single business model.

From the perspective of this research, this case is of particular interest as an example of a structure in which a substantial portion of customer payments may be generated not only through the interest rate itself, but also through additional service charges, including consulting fees, rental fees, subscription fees, processing fees, and other payments accompanying the credit product. Analysis of such models makes it possible to assess the actual cost of financing for the end borrower and to understand the economic logic behind the allocation of revenues within the group of companies.

Given the scale of the business, the international nature of the structure, the presence of Russian investment, and the participation of foreign managers in the management of operations within Vietnam, Takomo (Vay Xanh) itself, its corporate structure, as well as the individuals involved in managing the business and who are permanently located in Vietnam or regularly conduct business visits to the country, may be of interest for further

review and analysis. Such a review may include examination of corporate relationships, ownership structures, cash-flow movements, the allocation of functions among legal entities within the group, and the role of individual managers and employees in management decision-making.

At the same time, the information presented above is based on publicly available sources and requires additional verification through the analysis of corporate documents, government registries, financial statements, licensing materials, contractual documentation, and other available sources of information.

13. MoneyCat as an Example of a Multi-Entity Legal Structure

An interesting example is provided by the document structure used by MoneyCat. Formally, the loan is issued through the pawnshop company Saigon Credit at an interest rate that complies with legal requirements. However, analysis of one of the agreements shows that, despite a nominal interest rate of 1.52% per month and an additional loan management fee, the effective cost of credit for the customer reaches approximately 92% per annum.

At the same time, separate service or intermediary agreements may not be included in the main package of documents provided to the customer when the loan is issued. In a number of cases, information regarding additional charges, fees, or the total repayment amount may be displayed directly within the borrower's personal account rather than being fully disclosed within the loan agreement itself.

Document	Loan Amount	Total Repayment Amount	Additional Charges	Annualized Equivalent Rate
Saigon Credit / MoneyCat (Agreement No. 1988047)	2,000,000 VND	≈ 2,080,213 VND after 16 days	≈ 80,213 VND	≈ 92% per annum

*Pawnshop component only.

*The calculation was performed by the author by converting the aggregate contractual charges into an annualized equivalent rate and does not represent the company's official APR or regulatory disclosure.

Such a model makes it possible to distribute functions among multiple legal entities: one company acts as the lender or pawnshop operator, while another provides technological infrastructure, data processing, customer acquisition, or consulting services. As a result, the actual economics of the product may differ substantially from what is implied by the formal interest rate stated in the loan agreement.

Legal Entity	Role
Công ty TNHH MTV TM DV Saigon Credit Address: 23 Đường số 26A, Phường 10, Quận 6, TP.HCM Director: Phạm Phước Tài Website: moneycat.vn	Lender (Pawnshop)

During the review of contractual documentation associated with the MoneyCat brand in Vietnam, an NDA was identified that had been executed between two companies: **LENDTOP Company Limited** and **Data Nest Technologies JSC**. According to the document, one of the parties was **Công ty TNHH MTV LENDTOP (LENDTOP Company Limited)**, a company registered in Ho Chi Minh City in September 2018. The document identifies **Kirill Purtor** as the company's General Director at the time of signing.

The second party is **Data Nest Technologies JSC**, a technology company registered in Hanoi. Of particular interest is not the content of the NDA itself, but the existence of this relationship. In MoneyCat customer agreements, **Saigon Credit** appears as the lender. However, another legal entity, **LENDTOP**, appears in corporate documentation. At the same time, certain data-processing and technology-support functions appear, based on the available documents, to be performed by **Data Nest Technologies**.

Such fragmentation significantly complicates the analysis of the actual economic role of each participant. Formally, one company may state that it is not a lender and merely provides consulting or technology services. Another company may act as the formal party to the loan agreement. A third company may receive income for servicing the transaction or processing the application. As a result, it becomes more difficult to determine who actually makes the lending decision, who owns the loan portfolio, who receives the majority of the economic return, and who bears responsibility toward the borrower.

The following individuals associated with MoneyCat were identified from publicly available sources:

- [Mikhail Soppa](#) — publicly identified as COO of MoneyCat in 2023 and later as CEO of MoneyCat in 2024.
- [Alexander Laptev](#) — publicly identified as Head of Collection at MoneyCat.
- [Sergey Pan](#) — appears in several sources as an individual associated with the company's financial operations.

The existence of public employee profiles suggests the presence of a fully developed operational structure that includes product management, risk management, debt collection, and operational management functions.

At the time of preparing this report, MoneyCat remains one of the most recognizable micro-lending brands in Vietnam and continues to maintain a significant presence in the short-term consumer lending market. According to publicly available information, MoneyCat operates within a fully digital service model under a pawnshop license and utilizes digital customer acquisition, credit-scoring, and loan-servicing processes. The brand has been repeatedly mentioned in FiinGroup materials as one of the participants in Vietnam's PDL market.

At the same time, the available materials do not allow for a definitive confirmation of the allocation of functions among the entities mentioned above and therefore require further verification.

14. MoneyVeo as a Lender with Charges Equivalent to 1,110–1,120% per Annum

Moneyveo positions itself as a microfinance organization. FiinGroup classifies Moneyveo as one of the key participants in the market.

Document	Loan Amount	Total Repayment Amount	Additional Charges	Annualized Equivalent Rate*
Hồng Ân Thịnh Phát / MoneyVeo	6,200,000 VND	9,982,000 VND	3,782,000 VND	≈ 1,110–1,120% per annum

*The calculation was performed by the author by converting the aggregate contractual charges into an annualized rate equivalent and does not represent the company's official APR or regulatory disclosure.

Legal Structure

Legal Entity	Role	Registration Number
Hồng Ân Thịnh Phát Co., Ltd. (CÔNG TY TNHH HỒNG ÂN THỊNH PHÁT)	Lender / Pawnshop Operator, Issues the Loan	0316501210

Moneyveo Vietnam Co., Ltd. (CÔNG TY TNHH MONEYVEO VIỆT NAM)	Service Provider, Consulting, Data Processing, Loan Servicing	0316182035
Hồng Ân Thịnh Phát Co., Ltd.	Custodian of Collateral under the Asset Custody Agreement	0316501210

From the loan agreement:

Lender: Hồng Ân Thịnh Phát

Address: 498/25 Nguyễn Văn Khối, Phường 9, Quận Gò Vấp, TP.HCM

Director: Lê Đỗ Hồng Ân

From the service agreement:

Service Provider: Moneyveo Vietnam

Address: 21 Nguyễn Trung Ngạn, Bến Nghé, Quận 1, TP.HCM

Director: Olena Andronikova

What is particularly important is that the service agreement explicitly states: “*Bên cho vay / đối tác cho vay tại thời điểm này là Công ty TNHH Hồng Ân Thịnh Phát.*” In other words, Moneyveo explicitly identifies **Hồng Ân Thịnh Phát** as its lending partner.

From a structural perspective, the arrangement appears as follows: **Customer** → **Moneyveo Vietnam (marketing, scoring, data processing, fees)** → **Hồng Ân Thịnh Phát (pawnshop license, loan issuance)** → **Collateral custody agreement through Hồng Ân Thịnh Phát.**

15. Recommended Actions for Borrowers of Cay Vang, Vay Xanh, MoneyCat, VayVND, MoneyVeo, and Other Digital Lending Platforms

Borrowers who believe that the terms of their loan agreement may have violated the requirements of Vietnamese law or may have included non-transparent fees, additional charges, or other disputed payments are advised, first and foremost, to obtain a complete set of loan-related documents. This should include the loan agreement, repayment schedule, annexes to the agreement, consulting service agreements, service agreements, collateral agreements, asset rental agreements, insurance documents, and any other documents signed during the loan application process.

After obtaining the documents, it is advisable to conduct an independent analysis of the fee structure and determine the actual cost of credit, taking into account all commissions, service charges, penalties, consulting fees, insurance products, and other mandatory expenses. Particular attention should be paid to cases in which the loan was

structured through a pawnshop model or accompanied by additional agreements, as such mechanisms may be used to allocate part of the borrower's payments outside the formal 20% interest rate and present them as separate charges.

Borrowers are also advised to independently preserve all information displayed within the mobile application or personal account of the lending platform. Screenshots should be taken showing the loan origination date, the amount of funds actually received, accrued interest, fees, service charges, penalties, the total outstanding balance, the repayment schedule, transaction history, and all payments made.

Particular importance should be attached to screenshots that allow comparison between the amount of money actually received by the borrower and the amount the company subsequently demands to be repaid. In some cases, information displayed within the mobile application may contain details that are not included in the contract itself or are presented in a more detailed manner. For this reason, borrowers are advised to retain not only contractual documents but also all information displayed within their personal account.

Borrowers are further advised to preserve copies of SMS messages, push notifications, emails, messenger conversations, recordings of telephone calls, advertising materials, and any other communications received from company representatives. If threats, psychological pressure, contact with relatives, employers, or other third parties have occurred, such incidents should be documented as thoroughly as possible, including telephone numbers, dates, times, and the content of the communications.

In the event that a mobile application is deleted, an account is blocked, the user interface is modified, or information displayed in the personal account is altered, previously saved screenshots and copies of documents may become highly significant when communicating with government authorities or pursuing legal action. For this reason, borrowers are advised to create a dedicated archive of evidence containing contracts, annexes, bank statements, receipts, payment records, correspondence, screenshots, and any other materials related to obtaining and servicing the loan.

Where doubts exist regarding the legality of charges, borrowers may seek independent legal advice to assess whether the agreement complies with applicable Vietnamese law and whether all charges imposed are legally justified. Particular attention should be paid to situations in which the total cost of the loan substantially exceeds the amount of money actually received by the borrower, or where a significant portion of payments is structured as additional services, consulting fees, rental payments, or other service charges.

If a borrower believes that unlawful debt collection methods have been used, that pressure has been exerted on relatives, that personal data has been disclosed, or that other forms of conduct not permitted by law have occurred, it is recommended that all available evidence be preserved and reported to the appropriate authorities.

Where there are indications of potential legal violations, borrowers may submit complaints to local police departments, consumer protection authorities, and other government agencies authorized to review citizens' complaints. When filing such complaints, borrowers are encouraged to provide the most complete set of documentation and evidence possible, including contracts, annexes, payment records, bank statements, screenshots from mobile applications, correspondence with company representatives, and a detailed description of the circumstances surrounding the origination and servicing of the loan.

Possession of a complete set of documents and supporting evidence significantly increases the likelihood of an objective review of the complaint, the conduct of appropriate investigative measures, and the establishment of the actual facts governing the relationship between the borrower and the lending organization.

16. Recommended Areas of Review for the State Bank of Vietnam (SBV)

In order to understand the actual business structure and sources of revenue, it may be advisable for regulators to examine not only the legal entities directly named in agreements with borrowers, but also the entire group of companies involved in customer acquisition, marketing, credit scoring, loan origination, payment processing, loan servicing, and debt collection. Modern digital lending models often distribute different functions among multiple interconnected entities, meaning that analysis of a single legal entity may not always reveal the actual organization of the business.

As a first step, it is recommended to identify the ultimate beneficial owners of all companies associated with the brand under review. Particular attention may be warranted with respect to foreign legal entities registered outside Vietnam, as well as individuals who effectively control strategic decision-making, provide financing to the business, or participate in profit distribution. Formal ownership structures do not always reflect actual control mechanisms; therefore, the review should encompass the full network of related entities and individuals.

An equally important area of review is the analysis of banking flows and the movement of funds among all entities within the group. Examination may include payments received from borrowers, distributions to investors, intra-group transfers, payments for consulting,

marketing, IT services, and other operational services, as well as cross-border transfers made to foreign companies. Such analysis can help determine where profits are concentrated, which entities ultimately receive the funds, and whether the movement of funds is consistent with the declared business model.

Contractual relationships among affiliated companies also warrant separate examination. Particular attention may be given to service agreements, licensing arrangements, software-use agreements, outsourcing contracts, marketing agreements, management contracts, and consulting agreements. Such documents can provide insight into how functions, expenses, and revenues are allocated among members of the group and help identify which entities are actually performing key business functions.

The infrastructure used for data storage and processing is another area of significant interest. Regulators may consider determining the location of CRM systems, databases, and other information resources, identifying the owners of software platforms, establishing where scoring systems are operated, and determining in which jurisdiction lending decisions are made. It may also be important to identify which entities have access to borrowers' personal data and how external data providers, analytical platforms, and risk-assessment models are utilized.

Particular attention may also be given to debt collection procedures. The review may include internal collection policies, communication scripts used by collection personnel, procedures governing interactions with borrowers and their relatives, the use of automated communication systems, and the involvement of third-party collection agencies. The objective of such analysis is to determine whether the procedures employed are consistent with applicable laws and regulatory requirements.

Another important area of examination concerns the collection, storage, and use of customers' personal data. Regulators may seek to establish the legal basis for obtaining access to borrower information, identify the purposes for which such information is processed, determine which individuals and entities have access to the data, and assess compliance with requirements governing data protection and information security.

In addition, it may be necessary to analyze the payment infrastructure supporting the business. This includes identifying the banks and payment systems through which transactions are processed, determining which intermediaries participate in payment processing, establishing whether additional settlement centers exist, and identifying the legal entities involved in receiving payments from customers and disbursing funds to borrowers. Analysis of payment routes can assist in reconstructing the actual financial architecture of the business and identifying key nodes within the flow of funds.

Particular importance should be attached to identifying all foreign companies associated with the brands under review. Such examination may include entities involved in financing operations, software development, marketing, personnel management, analytics and credit scoring, data storage, and ownership of intellectual property. Special attention may be warranted with respect to structures registered in low-tax jurisdictions or entities performing functions critical to the operation of the business.

Only a comprehensive examination of corporate structures, financial flows, contractual relationships, information systems, and the allocation of functions among affiliated entities can establish the actual management framework, identify sources of revenue, understand profit-allocation mechanisms, and determine the real participants in the business regardless of which legal entities are formally identified in agreements with borrowers.

17. Recommended Areas of Review for Vietnamese Law Enforcement Authorities

Given that a number of companies operating in Vietnam's digital lending market have continued their activities following the large-scale investigations and law-enforcement actions conducted between 2020 and 2025, it may be advisable to undertake a further comprehensive review of their corporate structures, financial flows, and actual business organization.

Particular attention should be given to coordinating review activities at the level of the central units of the Ministry of Public Security of Vietnam (MPS), as the activities of the companies under examination are often interprovincial and cross-border in nature, while certain elements of their infrastructure may be distributed across multiple provinces of Vietnam as well as foreign jurisdictions.

In this regard, it may be appropriate to review the validity of Temporary Residence Cards (TRC) held by foreign employees and managers across all legal entities directly or indirectly associated with lenders, service companies, technology platforms, and other participants within the structures under examination. Particular attention should be given to the registered and actual residential addresses of foreign specialists, their travel history into and out of Vietnam, the legal basis for their presence in the country, the terms of their employment agreements, and the actual nature of the work they perform.

In addition, it may be necessary to determine where key employees actually perform their work, whether remote workplaces, home offices, coworking facilities, or third-party contractor infrastructure are utilized. Particular interest may lie in identifying individuals

who effectively make decisions relating to credit policy, risk management, credit scoring, debt collection, cash-flow management, information technology, and strategic business development. A person's formal job title does not always reflect their actual role within the management structure; therefore, any review should seek to identify the actual decision-making hierarchy, including foreign consultants, managers, and individuals exercising control through affiliated foreign companies.

Separate attention should be given to identifying the location of employees responsible for developing scoring models, managing loan portfolios, conducting debt collection activities, overseeing information technology systems, performing financial control functions, and processing data, as these functions may be distributed among multiple legal entities and across different countries.

Given the cross-border nature of the business under review, it may be advisable to establish cooperation between investigative units, immigration authorities, and border-control agencies in order to obtain timely information regarding the movement of individuals occupying key positions within the companies concerned. Particular attention should be paid to executives, foreign specialists, and other individuals who may possess information regarding ownership structures, financial flows, scoring systems, debt collection procedures, and the actual allocation of functions among affiliated companies.

The implementation of these measures may assist in establishing the actual management structure of the business, identifying the individuals responsible for key decisions, determining the real centers of control, and obtaining information necessary for further examination of the activities of the companies under review.

18. Recommended Areas of Review for Tax Authorities

In addition to questions relating to compliance with lending regulations, particular attention should be paid to the tax aspects of companies operating in Vietnam's digital lending market. The international nature of many of the structures examined, the presence of foreign investors, overseas management companies, cross-border service agreements, and distributed operational infrastructure create a need to verify whether all participants within a group have properly reported income, expenses, and tax obligations.

As part of such a review, it may be advisable to determine what portion of the income generated from lending activities actually remains in Vietnam and what portion may be redistributed to affiliated foreign entities. Particular attention may be warranted in situations where a substantial share of the economic value is generated through activities conducted within Vietnam, while a significant portion of profits is subsequently

transferred through consulting services, licensing fees, IT support services, marketing services, data-processing activities, risk-management functions, software-use arrangements, or other intra-group agreements. Such mechanisms may be used both for legitimate international business operations and for the allocation of profits across multiple jurisdictions, making them an important subject for examination by tax authorities.

Cross-border payments between affiliated companies also warrant separate analysis. It may be appropriate to review transfers made to foreign contractors, payments for the use of software and intellectual property, settlements with international marketing platforms, and agreements for consulting and management services. Examination of such transactions can help identify the ultimate recipients of funds and assess whether the payment structure corresponds to the actual economic substance of the work performed and services provided.

Particular attention should also be paid to compensation arrangements involving foreign managers and key personnel. According to information provided by market participants and former industry employees, in some cases a model may be used in which official salaries paid in Vietnam are maintained at relatively modest levels, while an additional portion of compensation is paid through foreign group entities. Such payments may be made through international payroll platforms, foreign bank accounts, service agreements, consulting contracts, or other settlement mechanisms involving affiliated overseas companies. This information requires further verification; however, if confirmed, it may be relevant in assessing the completeness of personal income declarations, the accuracy of tax calculations, and the payment of mandatory social contributions.

Tax authorities may also find it useful to establish a complete list of foreign legal entities participating in the activities of the groups under review. These may include companies involved in financing operations, software development, marketing and customer acquisition, personnel management, credit scoring and analytics, data processing, and ownership of intellectual property. Particular attention may be warranted in cases where key assets, technologies, and profits are concentrated outside Vietnam while substantial operational activity continues within the country.

To obtain an objective picture, it may be advisable to compare the size of a company's loan portfolio, the volume of customer payments, the number of borrowers, employee headcount, marketing expenditures, declared profits, and taxes actually paid. Such analysis may reveal potential discrepancies between the scale of actual operations and the financial results reflected in official reporting.

Given the international nature of the structures under review, any tax examination should extend beyond local legal entities operating directly in Vietnam and encompass the entire group of affiliated companies involved in customer acquisition, loan origination, data processing, risk management, debt collection, and revenue allocation. Only a comprehensive analysis of corporate relationships, financial flows, and cross-border transactions can determine where business profits are actually generated, how they are distributed within the group, and in which jurisdictions their ultimate recipients are located.

19. Conclusion

The histories of Cashwagon, Doctor Dong/Cay Vang, and Takomo/Vay Xanh demonstrate that the market did not cease to exist following the first major investigations. Instead, corporate structures became more complex, functions were redistributed among multiple legal entities, and service-based, consulting, and pawnshop-related models became more widely used. For this reason, any modern investigation into the activities of PDL companies requires analysis not of an individual brand, but of the entire chain of participants involved in customer acquisition, credit scoring, loan origination, loan servicing, and revenue distribution.

As some brands disappeared, others emerged. Following investigations and regulatory reviews, new market participants continued operating, new legal structures appeared, and new business models were developed. However, all of them are allegedly operating within a legal gray area that may involve elevated lending charges outside the scope of official regulatory limitations. Brands such as MoneyCat, Takomo (currently Vay Xanh), Cay Vang, MoneyVeo, VayVND, and a number of other digital lending platforms continue to maintain a presence in the market. At the same time, the underlying business models have become significantly more complex. Instead of a direct “lender–borrower” relationship, structures increasingly involve multiple legal entities, service companies, marketing platforms, consulting agreements, collateral arrangements, and various forms of additional charges.

Particular attention should be given to the history of Doctor Dong, which later operated under the Cay Vang brand. Despite extensive law-enforcement attention directed toward the pawnshop-licensed digital lending sector after 2023, the business continued to develop by adapting its organizational structure and operational processes to changing conditions. A similar evolution can be observed in the case of Takomo, which rebranded as Vay Xanh and continues to generate returns within the Vietnamese market for foreign investors.

This represents the principal conclusion of the present research. The history of the market demonstrates not the disappearance of controversial business models, but their continuous transformation. Regulators investigate one set of structures, while the market responds through the creation of new legal entities, new brands, and new mechanisms for distributing functions among affiliated companies.

The moral dimension of this issue also deserves separate consideration. Over recent years, public debate in Vietnam has repeatedly focused on the activities of digital lending companies. Questions regarding the cost of borrowing, debt collection practices, and the social burden placed on borrowers have been raised in the media, on social networks, and by various government authorities. Despite these concerns, the market continues to attract foreign investors, consultants, and managers who view Vietnam as one of the fastest-growing consumer lending markets in Asia.

As a result, an evident social conflict emerges. On one side are millions of citizens for whom microloans serve as a means of addressing short-term financial difficulties. On the other side are companies and investors for whom this segment represents a highly profitable business opportunity. This is why questions concerning ownership transparency, sources of financing, the actual cost of credit, and debt collection practices extend far beyond ordinary corporate analysis and acquire broader social significance.

For this reason, the focus of any review should not be a single company or a single brand. The entire credit-product value chain should be examined: who acquires the customer, who collects personal data, who makes the lending decision, where the scoring system is located, who provides the funding, through which structures the financial flows pass, who receives the majority of the revenues, and who conducts debt collection activities.

Only such a comprehensive approach makes it possible to establish the actual architecture of the business, identify the true beneficiaries, and understand how Vietnam's modern digital lending market operates, regardless of which legal entities are formally identified in agreements with borrowers.

Author's Statement

This report has been prepared on the basis of information obtained from open and publicly available sources, including corporate registries, court documents, public publications, official statements of government authorities, media reports, company documents, and other information available in the public domain at the time the research was conducted.

The conclusions presented herein are the result of an independent analysis of the collected materials and do not replace an official investigation, which may only be conducted by the competent government authorities.

The author possesses additional materials, working notes, information regarding corporate relationships, organizational structures, market participants, and other circumstances that have not been included in this report due to security considerations, source confidentiality, or the need for further verification.

In the event of an official investigation by the competent authorities, the author is prepared to provide assistance within the limits of applicable law, including the provision of additional materials, explanations, and information that may help establish the factual circumstances surrounding the activities of the companies under review, identify corporate relationships, trace financial flows, and clarify other matters relevant to the investigation.

The primary purpose of this research is to contribute to greater transparency in the digital lending market, promote the protection of consumers of financial services, and identify potential violations of law where such violations may exist.

The following materials were used in the preparation of this report:

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50. [EIB ASIA / MANUTA Agreement](#)
51. [MoneyCat Agreement](#)
52. [MoneyVeo Agreement](#)